



The Epic Apparel Effect

An Indian-origin Hong Kong-based enterprise with a footprint across Asia, anchored by Western design studios, is steadily growing its industrial presence in India while making an emphatic statement with its new Bhubaneswar campus. For Epic Group, Trimetro is far more than just another garment factory; it demonstrates how a company rooted in Indian ethos abroad can spearhead a more innovative, sustainable, and people-centric model for the entire industry.

The story of the Hong Kong-based Epic Group defies the usual narrative. It did not begin as a large Indian manufacturing house expanding overseas. Its roots lie in a meager trading house shaped outside India. For over four decades, Ranjan Mahtani, now Chairman, together with Vice Chairmen Sunil Daryanani and Dinesh Virwani, built Epic into a global apparel B2B powerhouse with a workforce of more than 35,000. With 18 manufacturing facilities spanning Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Jordan, and India, and an annual output of 120 million garments estimated to grow to 150 million in the next 18 months, Epic operates at the scale of a major global player. The enterprise was already in Bangladesh and Jordan by 2000, and today, the group aims to leave a visible mark in India with 40 years of experience and research behind its Bhubaneswar plant.

That is why the Bhubaneswar factory, as advanced as it is, carries significance beyond sheer capacity.

Trimetro, Epic's Odisha facility, represents a next-generation manufacturing unit for the industry worldwide. In business terms, it is also a bold statement: Epic views India not merely as another sourcing location but as a stage to demonstrate a broader model of innovation, sustainability, and industrial growth. Mahtani captures the ambition succinctly when he says that "India is not an opportunistic entry for the group but a long-term commitment to building capability with global standards."

Epic's hallmark is its characteristic pivot-ahead-of-the-curve model. The company's origins trace back to the mid-1980s, when Mahtani was sent to Bangladesh to salvage orders that had stalled amid disputes between agents and factories. Instead of retreating, he stayed, repaired the chain, sourced fabric, and fulfilled the orders. That episode became more than a story; it established the instinct that would define Epic: stay close to the problem, move quickly, and build what is missing. As Mahtani recalls, "the early years were a period of learning alongside factories, customers and the country itself," and the enduring discipline was simple: "be transparent, keep your word and keep improving the system." This became the company's DNA over time. The early years were as improvised as they were formative. Dhaka presented a challenging operating environment, capital was scarce, and the first office doubled as living space. Yet the business

grew rapidly because it earned a reputation for delivering what it promised. The culture wasn't forged in workshops alone; it was shaped through shared hardship, candor, and consistent follow-through. In that sense, Epic's evolution carries a distinctly Indian temperament: a bias for endurance, relationship-based trust, and institution-building through adversity rather than flashy display.

That instinct surfaced repeatedly as the business expanded. When industrial washing capability was lacking, Epic helped create it. When embroidery standards needed boosting, it invested early. When visibility between factories and customers became crucial, it built digital tracking long before such systems were common. By 1995, realizing that a middleman model had limited long-term value, the company decisively moved into manufacturing and established its first factory in Dhaka.

That shift produced defining chapters in the group's growth. In Bangladesh, Epic built facilities designed not only to add capacity but to set benchmarks. The Cosmopolitan Industries venture, which was developed after Mahtani acquired the Epic brand in 2005 and regrouped the business with Virwani and Daryanani, introduced advanced machinery, water-saving capabilities, and wrinkle-free trouser technology at a time when such investments were still exceptional. This business went on to supply wrinkle-free pants at scale to Levi's, Dockers, Haggar, JCPenney, Kohl's, Walmart, and Nordstrom.